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Writing women's worlds

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The question that remains, however, is the one I began with: Does using my knowledge of individuals for purposes beyond friendship and shared memories by fixing their words and lives for disclosure to a world beyond the one they live in constitute some sort of betrayal? As someone who moves between worlds, I feel that confronting the negative images I know to exist in the United States toward Arabs is one way to honor the kindness they have shown me. So is challenging stereotypical generalizations that ultimately make them seem more "other." Yet how will my critical ethnography be received? This is the dilemma all those of us who move back and forth between worlds must face as we juggle speaking for, speaking to, and, when we are "halfies," speaking from.

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I can only surmise from the reception of my first book how complex the local readings will be. My revelation, in *Veiled Sentiments*, of Bedouin individuals' attachments and vulnerabilities through their poetry was intended to inspire among Westerners a recognition of these people's everyday humanity; it met with another response in Egypt. When one woman heard someone read from the book a few of the poems she had recited years earlier, she exclaimed, half joking, "You've scandalized us!" For her, a book about particular people and everyday life in her community might seem little more than a public display of family secrets.

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My presentation of the way ideals of personal autonomy and independence were manifested in men's lives took on complex and different meanings in Egypt as well. A copy of a long review (in Arabic) of my book came to the

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attention of a local Awlad [unknown]Ali man who was a civil servant and aspiring official in the Egyptian government. He confronted my host with the article, angry that I had reported that they liked to carry guns, evade taxes, and guard their rights to settle their own disputes rather than let the government interfere. "This is your girl who wrote this!" the man accused. What happened then I will never know, since I was not there and heard only my host's version. He was, as usual, defiant, retorting that he had taught me everything I knew. And in any case, wasn't it true? Didn't the official have unlicensed guns? Did he report all 42 his sheep for tax purposes? The man admitted these facts but still wondered if it was right to publicize the situation.

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